

My vort for אלול was inspired by a number of people, including Rabbi Oelbaum, is as follows: We know that the month of אלול is distinctive in that every day we say וְיִשְׁעֵי אֲוִרֵי ה' לְדָוֶד. In that קאפיטל there's the pasuk אַחַת שְׁאַלְתִּי מֵאֵת ה' - there is only one thing that I'm asking for. Then we go home and we wash and we have a nice fresh roll and a little scrambled egg or whatever, and then we bentch. In bentching we say:

לָחֵן וּלְחֶסֶד וּלְרַחֲמִים וּלְרוּחַ הַצֵּלָה וְהַצְלָחָה בְּרַכָּה וְיִשׁוּעָה, נְחֵמָה, פְּרִנָּסָה וְכִלְכֵּלָה, וְרַחֲמִים, וְחַיִּים - I need, הקדוש ברוך הוא וְשָׁלוֹם, וְכָל טוֹב. And הקדוש ברוך הוא, in case I left anything out, וְחֶסֶד, אֵל וּמֶכֶל טוֹב לְעוֹלָם אֵל וְחֶסֶד. If I forgot something, please throw in all the other good stuff that you can do.

So hang on. Ten seconds ago, you said, I'm only asking you one thing, אַחַת שְׁאַלְתִּי. And now you're asking an entire list. It's an endless list. וְחֶסֶד, אֵל וּמֶכֶל טוֹב לְעוֹלָם אֵל וְחֶסֶד - it's an infinite list.

The תירוץ is there is one thing in bentching that we do not want. לא לִידֵי מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם - everything that I need should come directly from you, not from מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם. חס ושלום, we should never have to come on to מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם. Let me ask you a question. A kid comes home from school and he says, 'Ma, what's for supper?' So she gives him supper. Is that called מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם? An older kid asks, 'Daddy, I'm getting בר מצוה, can I have a Borsalino?' 'Okay, you can have a Borsalino.' Is that מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם? An even older kid comes along and says, 'Dad, can I borrow the car keys?' Is that מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם? And even better, 'Can I have a car?' Is that מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם? No, that's not מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם. Why? Because that's called משפחה, that's called your family. When you're getting something from your father, mother, and family, that's not מִתְנַת בְּשֵׁר וְדָם.

What are we asking Hashem? אַחַת שְׁאַלְתִּי מֵאֵת ה' ... שְׁבִתִּי בְּבֵית ה' כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּי - Hashem, I want to live in your house. I want to be part of your משפחה. I want to be close to you, as close as a father and a mother. When you ask שְׁבִתִּי בְּבֵית ה' כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּי, that I want to live in your house, then you can ask for everything. That's why when we bentch, we can ask for everything. May we be זוכה that וְחֶסֶד, אֵל וּמֶכֶל טוֹב, and to have a wonderful וְחֶסֶד, אֵל וּמֶכֶל טוֹב.

